THE BATTLE FOR GUADALCANAL

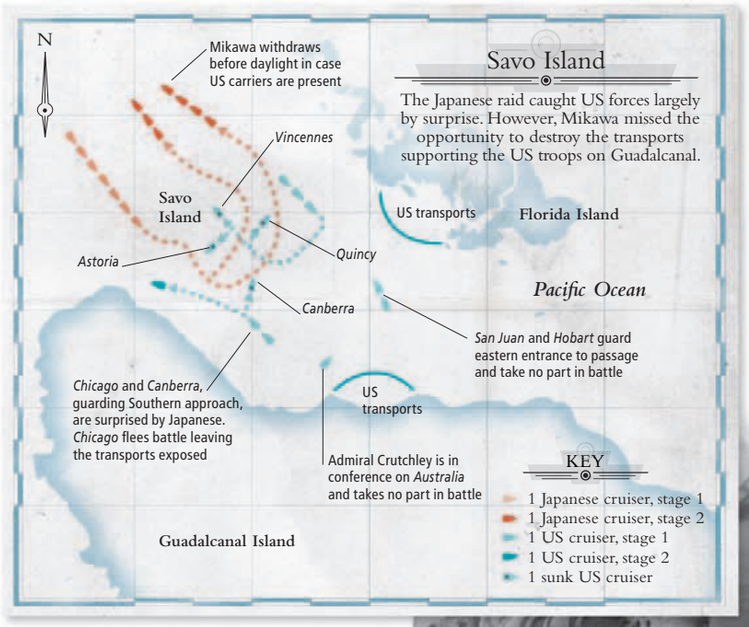
AMERICAN FORCES LANDED on Guadalcanal and other islands in the Eastern Solomons on August 7, 1942. As the Japanese were determined to retake Guadalcanal and the Americans equally determined to hold it, the island became the focus for intense naval warfare. The Japanese Navy was at first supremely confident, viewing the fighting as a chance to draw American forces into battle and destroy them. After a stunning initial victory at Savo Island, however, the Japanese failed to crush the Americans in fleet encounters at the Eastern Solomons and the Santa Cruz Islands. The US Navy equally failed to prevent the Japanese running the convoy ships of the "Tokyo Express" down New Georgia Sound at night to land reinforcements on Guadalcanal and shell the airbase at Henderson Field. The climax of the campaign came in two major night encounters in mid-November, known as the naval battle of Guadalcanal, during which the Japanese lost two battleships. Their attempt to retake the island was eventually abandoned. The Japanese Navy successfully evacuated troops from Guadalcanal in February 1943, but it had been unable to achieve decisive naval superiority.

THE BATTLE OF SAVO ISLAND

Japanese vice admiral Gunichi Mikawa, based at Rabaul, organized a rapid naval response to the initial American landings on Guadalcanal. With no air cover, Mikawa planned to attack under cover of darkness, as his cruisers were well trained in night-fighting. On the evening of August 8, the Allied naval forces covering the landings were far from alert. Admiral Frank Fletcher had withdrawn his carriers and British admiral Victor Crutchley, commanding the warships screening the landings, had departed from his station with his flagship *Australia* to discuss this move with the overall commander, Admiral Turner.

On the ships of the screening force it was hot and crews were tired. Captain Howard Bode, left in command on Crutchley's departure, slept soundly on board his cruiser *Chicago*. The approach of Mikawa's force was undetected until far too late. The destroyer *Patterson* raised the alarm at almost the same moment that Japanese floatplanes dropped flares to illuminate *Chicago* and the Australian cruiser *Canberra*. Hit by gunfire and torpedoes from four Japanese cruisers, *Canberra* was wrecked in minutes. Bode, rudely torn from his sleep, succeeded in extracting *Chicago* from the action with relatively little damage, but his flight left the rest of the ships exposed. Other Allied warships fatally hesitated to open fire on Japanese searchlights, unsure whether they would be hitting friendly vessels. The cruisers *Astoria*, *Quincy,* and *Vincennes* were all sunk after multiple hits from shells and torpedoes.

Mikawa could have gone on to destroy the Allied transport ships, but he was unaware that the US carrier aircraft were no longer there and wanted to get away before daylight. The Japanese cruiser *Kako* was sunk by a submarine on its way back from the action, a small consolation for the battered Allies.



Torpedo damage
Crewmen on the heavy cruiser USS *Chicago* cut away torpedo-damaged plating on the day after the battle of Savo Island.



THE BATTLE OF SAVO ISLAND

Date	August 8-9, 1942
Location	Solomon Islands
Result	Japanese victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES AND AUSTRALIA	JAPAN

COMMANDERS

Richmond K Turner Victor Crutchley	Gunichi Mikawa

FORCES

Ships: 5 heavy cruisers, 6 destroyers	**Ships:** 5 heavy cruisers, 2 light cruisers, 1 destroyer

LOSSES

Men: 1,077 **Ships:** 4 heavy cruisers	**Men:** 58 **Ships:** none